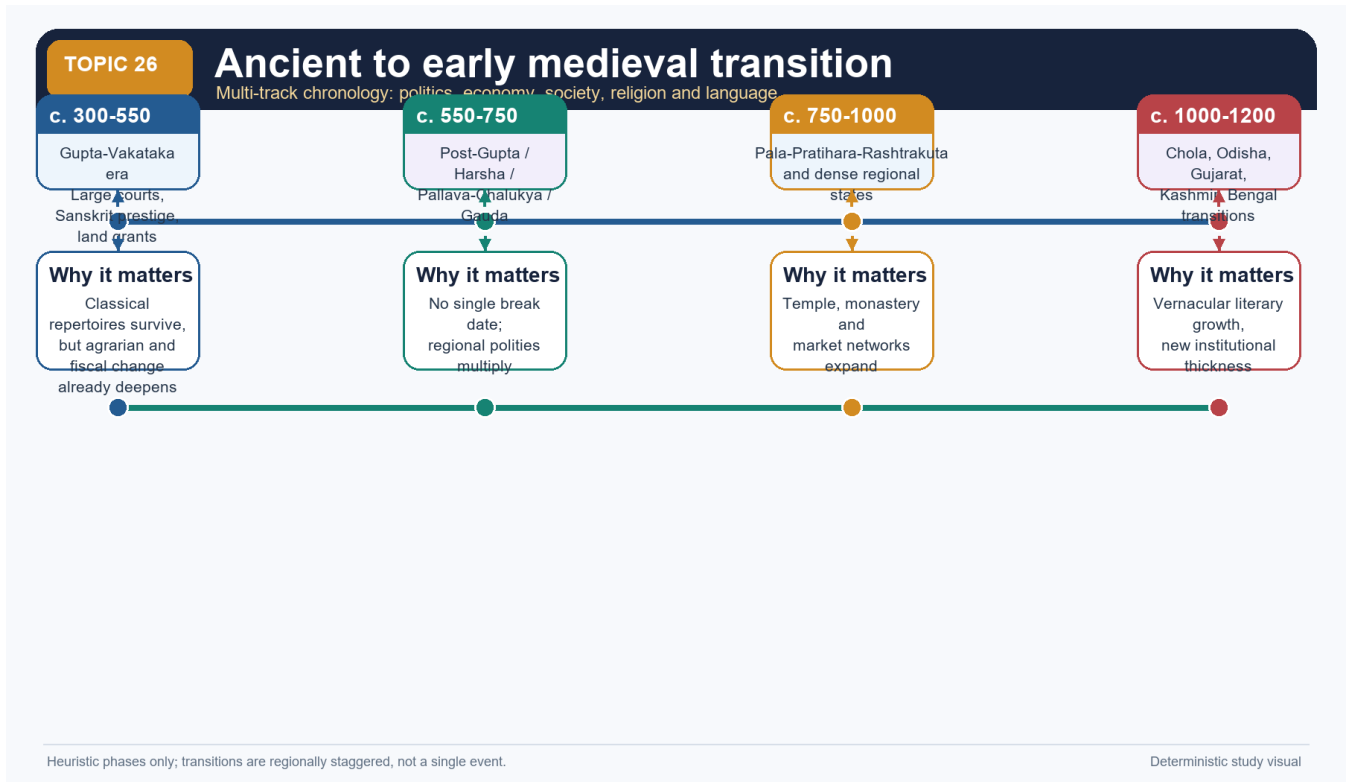


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned; exact wording locally preserved)

Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally through the repository's Topic 21 package and the 2024-2025 Mains routing notes. Gupta culture is a primary owner in Topic 21; Chola detail belongs to Topic 27; Topic 26 uses the question as a direct legacy bridge.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Gupta and Chola periods are both major contributors to Indian heritage and culture, but they do so through different political economies and institutional forms. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Gupta evidence includes Kalidasa, Aryabhata, early structural temples such as Deogarh, Udayagiri's Vaishnava royal symbolism, mature Sarnath-Mathura sculpture and the consolidation of Sanskrit prestige. This establishes the Gupta contribution to classical literary, scientific and iconographic repertoires. Chola evidence includes Brihadishvara, later great temple institutions, bronze Nataraja, extensive Tamil inscriptions and temple-centred labour and redistribution. This shows a more monumental, inscription-rich and institutionally dense cultural field. [ANALYSIS] The comparison itself is historically valuable: the Guptas offer a strongly classicised cultural vocabulary, while the Cholas intensify early medieval regional state culture into large temple-centred systems. [LIMIT] Neither period should be romanticised as universally prosperous or culturally homogeneous; both were socially stratified and regionally uneven. [VERDICT] Together they show how ancient repertoires survived through transformation - from Gupta classical prestige to Chola regional-institutional power. **Why this earns marks:** It directly compares the two periods, uses named evidence from both, explains what each proves and closes with a transition-focused verdict.

Verified PYQ 2 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)

Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate. (150 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally through Topic 22's verified package and the Ancient History routing ledger.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Pala period was the highest late-Indian institutional phase of Buddhism, although the phrase "most significant" must be qualified against earlier Ashokan and early-sangha milestones. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Nalanda, Vikramashila, Odantapuri and Somapura show concentrated mahavihara networks supported by agrarian surplus. Mahayana and Vajrayana scholasticism remained vibrant in these institutions, and figures such as Atisha reflect trans-Himalayan circulation of teachers and texts. Pala bronze, stone and manuscript traditions also influenced Nepal and Tibet. [ANALYSIS] In Topic 26 this matters because it disproves the simplistic idea that the early medieval period was only a story of Buddhist disappearance. It was also a period of transformed institutional concentration in eastern India. [LIMIT] The answer must not erase the foundational importance of the earlier Buddhist age or the uneven decline of Buddhism in other regions. [VERDICT] The Pala centuries therefore represent the decisive late-classical peak of Indian Buddhism in institutional, scholastic and trans-regional terms. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the superlative carefully, uses named institutional evidence and turns a religious question into a transition argument.

Verified PYQ 3 - GS-I Mains 2024 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)

Estimate the contribution of Pallavas of Kanchi for the development of art and literature of South India. (Answer in 150 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally in the official UPSC Mains 2024 GS Paper I.pdf and in Topic 23's solved package.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Pallavas of Kanchi were foundational because they linked art, literature, temple patronage and multilingual political culture in an early medieval regional state. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Mahendravarman I began the major rock-cut phase at sites such as Mandagapattu and Mamandur and is linked with *Mattavilasa-prahasana*. Narasimhavarman I's Mamallapuram programme turned stone experimentation into political landscape, while Narasimhavarman II Rajasimha's Shore Temple and Kailasanatha mark mature structural temple

development. Pallava literary culture includes Kanchi's Sanskrit scholarship, Dandin's association and bilingual Tamil-Sanskrit inscriptions. [ANALYSIS] In Topic 26, the question is significant because it shows how regionalisation created durable artistic and linguistic institutions rather than mere post-imperial decline. [LIMIT] Surviving evidence is heavily courtly and monumental; everyday cultural life is less evenly visible. [VERDICT] The Pallava contribution was therefore transitional and foundational at once: it regionalised power while expanding South India's long cultural legacy. **Why this earns marks:** It answers both art and literature, links them to early medieval state formation and ends with historical significance.

Verified PYQ 4 - Prelims GS-I 2025 Q14 (exact wording and official Set-A key held locally)

Who among the following rulers in ancient India had assumed the titles Mattavilasa, Vichitrachitta and Gunabhara?

- A. Mahendravarman I
- B. Simhavishnu
- C. Narasimhavarman I
- D. Simhavarman

Official local key status: Set-A official answer key present locally. Correct option: **A. Mahendravarman I.**

Explanation: The titles point to Mahendravarman I, the Pallava ruler associated with early rock-cut patronage, Kanchi's court culture and *Mattavilasa-prahasana*. Topic 26 uses the question because regional courts, temple patronage and literary prestige are core signs of early medieval transition. **Why this earns marks:** It joins factual recall to the wider logic of regional state culture.

Routed PYQ 5 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (exact event list preserved locally; official key unavailable)

1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman I
3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka I
4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest time?

Status: Original official paper held locally. The stem and event list are readable from the official paper; the option OCR is imperfect, and no official 2020 key is held locally.

Answer / route: INFERRED ORDER - 2 -> 4 -> 1 -> 3.

- Mahendravarman I belongs to the early 7th century.
- Gopala's foundation of the Pala dynasty belongs to the mid-8th century.
- The question specifies the rise of the Pratiharas **under King Bhoja**, that is the 9th-century Bhoja phase.
- Parantaka I belongs to the early 10th century.

Why this earns marks: It is a direct Topic 26 chronology discriminator: different regional histories are placed on one analytical line without pretending that the official 2020 key is locally secure.

Verified PYQ 6 - Prelims GS-I 2025 Q15 (exact wording locally preserved; official Set-A key available locally)

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of:

- A. Samudragupta
- B. Chandragupta II
- C. Kumaragupta I
- D. Skandagupta

Status: Exact wording preserved locally in the official 2025 Set-A paper. Official local answer: **B. Chandragupta II.**

Explanation: Faxian's journey belongs to the late Gupta world, but Topic 26 uses the question for a source-critical point: traveller evidence is selective, strong and bounded. Faxian is important for Buddhist geography and social observations, yet he is not a neutral administrative survey. **Why this earns marks:** It gives the official answer and the source-use caution that this topic requires.

Verified PYQ 7 - Prelims GS-I 2024 Q64 (exact wording and audited route preserved locally)

Sanghabhuti, an Indian Buddhist monk who travelled to China at the end of the fourth century CE, authored a commentary on:

- A. Prajnaparamita Sutra
- B. Visuddhimagga
- C. Sarvastivada Vinaya
- D. Lalitavistara

Status: Audited local route already preserved in Topic 25. Answer: **C. Sarvastivada Vinaya.**

Explanation: Topic 26 uses this question as evidence that late ancient and early medieval transitions still preserved strong scholastic and trans-Asian Buddhist channels. It is especially useful for the continuity side of the continuity-change debate. **Why this earns marks:** It turns a rare-name prelim item into evidence for institutional and intellectual connectivity.

Adjacent PYQ 8 - Prelims GS-I 2026 Q4 (exact wording held locally; provisional key not converted into an official answer here)

Which of the following temples has/have a Nagara-style shikhara?

1. Malegitti Shivalaya, Badami
2. Huchimalligudi Temple, Aihole
3. Dashavatara Temple, Deogarh
4. Virupaksha Temple, Pattadakal

Select the answer using the code given below.

Status: Exact wording preserved locally in the official 2026 Set-A paper. The repository also holds the provisional Set-A key, but the controlling rule does not convert a provisional key into an official answer.

Concept route: Deogarh is the obvious Nagara anchor. Virupaksha at Pattadakal is the Dravida side of the Pattadakal pair. Topic 26 includes the question because early medieval transition is also visible in temple-style regionalisation and the continued reworking of earlier forms. **Why this earns marks:** It uses the item honestly as adjacent evidence for stylistic regionalisation without faking official key certainty.

Routed PYQ 9 - Prelims GS-I 2021 Q34 (audited demand; exact local paper and key not held)

Locally audited demand: kingdoms of northern India after Gupta decline.

Status: Routed demand from the Ancient History Prelims ledger. Exact official paper text and key are not held locally.

Answer / route: The safe post-Gupta north Indian cluster includes Later Guptas, Maukharis, Pushyabhutis, Maitrakas and Gauda under Shashanka. If options mix northern and southern houses, eliminate Pallavas, Cholas or deeper Deccan lines unless the question explicitly asks for contrast.

Why this earns marks: It gives a real elimination route for Topic 26's north Indian transition without inventing unavailable wording or an unavailable key.

Routed PYQ 10 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q97 (audited demand; exact options not held locally)

Locally audited demand: matching historical places such as Bhilsa, Dwarasamudra, Girinagar and Sthanesvara with their state-dynasty contexts.

Status: Routed demand only. Official key unavailable locally; exact option wording not held in the repository.

Answer / route: Use fixed pairs, not a guessed letter:

- Sthanesvara = Thanesar, the Pushyabhuti-Harsha base.
- Girinagar = Junagadh / Girnar-Saurashtra zone.
- Bhilsa = Vidisha-Malwa region.
- Dwarasamudra = Hoysala centre and therefore later than Topic 26's core Harsha phase.

Why this earns marks: It teaches place-political discrimination honestly, without fabricating a missing option letter.

Broad topic coverage MCQs

Programmatic answer rotation for this section is strict A -> B -> C -> D with no consecutive repeats.

Workbook MCQ 01

Which statement best captures why no single transition date works for Topic 26?

- A. different domains changed at different speeds across regions
- B. all historians reject chronology
- C. medieval features appeared only after the Cholas
- D. political change always follows religious change by one century

Answer: A. This is the chapter's opening method: staggered transition, not one-event rupture.

Workbook MCQ 02

Why is c. AD 300-750 a useful heuristic phase?

- A. it begins exactly with all regional languages becoming literary
- B. it captures early land-grant expansion and post-imperial restructuring without claiming full uniformity
- C. it is the only phase any historian uses
- D. it excludes south India

Answer: B. The phase is a tool, not a law.

Workbook MCQ 03

What is the strongest political description of the post-Gupta centuries?

- A. absence of states
- B. single imperial continuity
- C. multiplication of regional and sub-regional polities
- D. permanent military paralysis

Answer: C. Upinder's strongest corrective is proliferation of state polities.

Workbook MCQ 04

In Topic 26, samantas are best understood as:

- A. village schoolteachers
- B. Buddhist monks only
- C. merchants with tax immunity
- D. subordinate or feudatory rulers within layered political hierarchies

Answer: D. The term belongs to distributed sovereignty, not to one rigid office.

Workbook MCQ 05

Which feature is most directly shown by many land-grant charters?

- A. transfer of fiscal and other rights to donees
- B. disappearance of all cultivator claims
- C. exact annual production totals
- D. abolition of royal authority

Answer: A. Fiscal rights, exemptions and jurisdiction are central charter clues.

Workbook MCQ 06

The safest distinction between brahmadeya and agrahara is that:

- A. both are identical everywhere and need no qualification
- B. both are Brahmana-linked grant or settlement terms, but context determines emphasis
- C. agrahara refers only to Buddhist villages
- D. brahmadeya refers only to medieval Kashmir

Answer: B. The chapter requires contextual rather than mechanical use.

Workbook MCQ 07

Which statement best describes agrarian frontier expansion?

- A. it was unrelated to ecology
- B. it always destroyed all earlier local cults instantly
- C. it involved clearance, irrigation, incorporation and new hierarchies
- D. it happened only in the Ganga plain

Answer: C. Agrarian expansion is ecological, political and social at once.

Workbook MCQ 08

What is the strongest caution about frontier groups?

- A. every frontier group became a caste in the same way
- B. frontier societies are historically invisible
- C. they mattered only after AD 1200
- D. autonomy, alliance, resistance and rulership can all emerge from frontier contact

Answer: D. That is why one-way teleology is unsafe.

Workbook MCQ 09

Which cluster belongs most closely to Sharma's Indian feudalism thesis?

- A. land grants, intermediaries, labour dependence and urban decline signals
- B. strong salaried bureaucracy and cash-only economy
- C. total disappearance of religion from politics
- D. full village democracy

Answer: A. Those are the recurrent features of the thesis.

Workbook MCQ 10

The Mukhia-type critique is strongest when it says:

- A. land grants do not exist
- B. the European manor-serf complex cannot be copied onto India without distortion
- C. regional evidence is useless
- D. all decline arguments are nationalist myths

Answer: B. The critique blocks mechanical analogy, not all agrarian change.

Workbook MCQ 11

Burton Stein's segmentary-state model mainly highlights:

- A. a perfectly centralised fiscal state
- B. the complete absence of ritual
- C. sacred kingship with limited effective reach beyond core zones
- D. pan-Indian bureaucratic uniformity

Answer: C. The model is about uneven reach, not about non-existence of power.

Workbook MCQ 12

Which description best fits Chattopadhyaya's regional-state approach?

- A. no political change after the Guptas
- B. early medieval India was only a dark age
- C. state society vanished into isolated villages
- D. regional and sub-regional polities formed through grants, locality and social incorporation

Answer: D. That is the key corrective to total-breakdown narratives.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which statement best captures the urban question?

- A. some old centres declined, but others survived or newly grew
- B. all old urban centres grew continuously
- C. no new trade nodes appeared
- D. archaeology has already resolved every case

Answer: A. Topic 26 prefers urban transformation with local decline.

Workbook MCQ 14

What were mandapikas in Upinder's discussion?

- A. military camps only
- B. intermediate exchange nodes between periodic markets and larger trade centres
- C. Brahmana marriage halls
- D. Buddhist forest monasteries

Answer: B. They are crucial to reconfigured early medieval exchange.

Workbook MCQ 15

Which statement on monetisation is safest?

- A. fewer gold coin types prove barter economy everywhere
- B. early medieval India had no money at all
- C. mixed monetary systems, money of account and regional shortages matter more than simple "scarcity"
- D. all rulers minted identical silver systems

Answer: C. Coin change is more complex than collapse.

Workbook MCQ 16

Why should texts not be treated as caste census data?

- A. because caste did not exist before the British
- B. because texts only describe kings
- C. because all texts are fictional
- D. because prescriptive ranking language and mixed-caste lists classify rather than count society

Answer: D. This is one of the chapter's most important source cautions.

Workbook MCQ 17

Which is the strongest evidence route for untouchability in the transition era?

- A. traveller and textual evidence such as the chandala references, used with caution
- B. temple plans alone
- C. only Mahayana doctrine
- D. bilingual inscriptions alone

Answer: A. Untouchability evidence must be strong but source-qualified.

Workbook MCQ 18

What is the best formulation of Brahmanisation in Topic 26?

- A. total erasure of all local cults
- B. a negotiated but unequal linkage of land, legitimacy, ritual specialists and localisation
- C. only a linguistic shift into Sanskrit
- D. a process confined to north India

Answer: B. The chapter rejects both denial and one-way conquest language.

Workbook MCQ 19

Which statement about stridhana is safest?

- A. it had no legal recognition at all
- B. it made inheritance fully equal
- C. it marks a bounded but real sphere of women's property claims within patriarchy
- D. it belonged only to temple women

Answer: C. Topic 26 requires precisely that balanced line.

Workbook MCQ 20

What is the key caution about early medieval temple women?

- A. they were identical to every later devadasi stereotype
- B. they had no relation to donation
- C. they never appear in inscriptions
- D. their institutional identity in inscriptions should not be collapsed into much later categories

Answer: D. Upinder's Chola note is explicit on this point.

Workbook MCQ 21

Which sentence on bhakti is strongest?

- A. it created vernacular devotional publics but remained institutionally embedded in hierarchy
- B. it abolished all caste boundaries
- C. it was only a Sanskrit court phenomenon
- D. it ended temple-centred religion

Answer: A. This is the balanced line used in Topic 23 and carried into Topic 26.

Workbook MCQ 22

What is the safest statement on tantra in the early medieval transition?

- A. it existed only outside institutions
- B. it marks ritual and sectarian innovation across both Buddhist and Brahmanical worlds
- C. it replaced all bhakti
- D. it ended pilgrimage

Answer: B. Topic 26 treats tantra as part of broader institutional change.

Workbook MCQ 23

Which phrase best describes the temple in this chapter?

- A. only a site of private prayer
- B. a purely architectural specimen
- C. a ritual, fiscal, labour, memory and legitimacy institution
- D. an anti-political zone

Answer: C. Temple as institution is one of the central transition arguments.

Workbook MCQ 24

What is vernacularisation?

- A. disappearance of all prestige languages
- B. translation of every Sanskrit text into one local language
- C. replacement of temples by courts
- D. growing literary and political use of regional languages in conversation with Sanskrit

Answer: D. The interaction model is decisive here.

Workbook MCQ 25

What is the best way to use Nalanda in Topic 26?

- A. as evidence of scholastic concentration supported by agrarian surplus
- B. as proof that every number reported by pilgrims is exact
- C. as the only educational institution in India
- D. as a purely urban-commercial site with no religious role

Answer: A. Nalanda connects land, institution, travel and knowledge.

Workbook MCQ 26

Which cluster best captures eastern India's early medieval transition?

- A. complete historical silence after the Guptas
- B. charters, agrarian expansion, monasteries and regional state visibility
- C. only tribal autonomy with no state formation
- D. only maritime trade without land change

Answer: B. Topic 22's east is a major transition laboratory.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which sentence on the Tamil region is strongest?

- A. it remained outside the transition
- B. it only copied Gupta models
- C. brahmadeya, bhakti and temple-centred locality made it a key early medieval zone
- D. it had no political rivalry

Answer: C. Topic 23 and Topic 27 together support this.

Workbook MCQ 28

Which statement best captures localisation and connectivity together?

- A. localisation ended all long-distance contact
- B. Indian Ocean links mattered only to ports and never to villages
- C. connectivity and rooted agrarian localities often sustained each other
- D. regional cultures grew through rooted localities that remained linked to wider routes

Answer: D. Option D captures the full synthesis best: rooted localities and wider routes grew together, rather than in isolation.

Workbook MCQ 29

Which classification best fits the chapter's legacy method?

- A. survival, transformation and reinvention
- B. glory, fall and rebirth
- C. empire, republic and modernity
- D. temple, mosque and church

Answer: A. The chapter's modern afterlife argument depends on that three-part classification.

Workbook MCQ 30

Why must modern historical consciousness be handled carefully?

- A. because archaeology is irrelevant
- B. because present political uses of the past are not the same as historical explanation
- C. because heritage is always neutral
- D. because no ancient legacy survives

Answer: B. Topic 26 explicitly separates historical analysis from presentist appropriation.

Workbook MCQ 31

How does Topic 26 connect to Topic 27?

- A. Topic 26 ends the story before the south becomes important
- B. Topic 27 replaces all early medieval processes with a new civilisational break
- C. Topic 27 intensifies regional-state, temple and maritime processes already visible in Topic 26
- D. there is no connection between the topics

Answer: C. The Cholas are a bridge, not an unrelated afterthought.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which conclusion is the most defensible for a long answer on Topic 26?

- A. medieval India began only with foreign conquest
- B. the period is best ignored as a confused interval
- C. continuity alone explains everything
- D. early medieval transition produced regional cultures, durable institutions and new political-social forms

Answer: D. That is the package's final historical significance verdict.

Remedial MCQ 01

Which sentence should be rejected first in a weak Topic 26 answer?

- A. "The medieval period in India began suddenly in 1206 and all earlier centuries were still ancient."
- B. "Different spheres changed at different speeds."
- C. "Regional comparison matters."
- D. "Land grants are historically important."

Answer: A. This is exactly the rupture trap the package is designed to fix.

Remedial MCQ 02

What is the best corrective to "land grants prove kings simply lost power"?

- A. all grants were fake
- B. grants could also integrate elites, expand cultivation and legitimise rulers
- C. no grants existed before the Cholas
- D. grants mattered only to monks

Answer: B. Upinder's correction is integrative and legitimising, not collapse-only.

Remedial MCQ 03

Which statement about caste lists is safest?

- A. they are full demographic surveys
- B. they only describe foreigners
- C. they reveal classificatory and ranking efforts more than exact population composition
- D. they show equality among all occupational groups

Answer: C. This prevents the most common text-as-census mistake.

Remedial MCQ 04

What is the strongest correction to "temples only mattered ritually"?

- A. temples were only archives
- B. temples had no employees
- C. temples were only merchant houses
- D. temples also managed labour, gifts, legitimacy and redistribution

Answer: D. Topic 26 treats temple history as institutional history.

Remedial MCQ 05

Which statement should be avoided in frontier history?

- A. every frontier group followed one inevitable path into caste society
- B. frontier groups could resist or become chiefs
- C. ecological frontiers mattered to political change
- D. source bias is strong

Answer: A. Non-teleology is the central corrective.

Remedial MCQ 06

What is the best summary of the Mukhia critique for an exam answer?

- A. Indian feudalism is a useless topic
- B. one must question a direct import of the European manor-serf model
- C. kings disappeared after the Guptas
- D. no agrarian inequality existed

Answer: B. It is a conceptual caution, not a denial of all structural change.

Remedial MCQ 07

Which line best corrects a weak language answer?

- A. Sanskrit vanished once Tamil bhakti appeared
- B. regional languages only carried village gossip
- C. Sanskrit prestige and vernacular growth increasingly coexisted in layered ways
- D. scripts and languages are identical

Answer: C. This is the safe language-history verdict.

Remedial MCQ 08

Which statement best corrects civilisational triumphalism in the legacy section?

- A. legacy means unchanged survival
- B. legacy means only pride and glory
- C. modern identity claims are identical to early medieval consciousness
- D. legacy should be classified as survival, transformation and reinvention

Answer: D. This is the most disciplined way to handle legacy.

Original Mains Practice 01 - 10 marks - 150 words

Explain why no single date can mark the transition from ancient to medieval India.

Model answer: [CLAIM] No single date can mark the ancient-to-medieval transition because the change was multi-domain and regionally staggered. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Gupta imperial prestige persisted even as land grants and feudatory structures deepened. Post-Gupta north India saw Kannauj, Gauda and Kamarupa emerge in new ways, while the south developed Pallava-Chalukya regional state systems and later Chola intensification. Upinder Singh's early medieval framing and Chattopadhyaya's regional-state perspective both show that polity, agrarian change, urban transformation, bhakti and vernacularisation moved at different speeds. [LIMIT] A heuristic split such as c. AD 300-750 and c. AD 750-1200 remains useful, but only as a teaching device. [VERDICT] The transition is therefore best seen as uneven early medieval reorganisation, not as a one-date civilisational break.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the date problem, gives named evidence and turns chronology into analysis.

Original Mains Practice 02 - 10 marks - 150 words

How far did land grants restructure rural society in early medieval India?

Model answer: [CLAIM] Land grants significantly restructured rural society, but they did so unevenly and not in a mechanically identical way everywhere. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Upinder's Prabhavati Gupta charter shows exemptions, tax rights and control language; the Pulankurichi inscription distinguishes donee and cultivator rights; Sharma's eastern and peninsular chapters connect grants to frontier cultivation, brahmana settlement and new hierarchies. Such grants created or strengthened intermediaries, tied agrarian surplus to religious or political institutions and gave new social prestige to donees. [LIMIT] A charter is a claim, not a full ethnography; implementation varied by locality, prior occupants and resistance. [VERDICT] Land grants were therefore among the strongest engines of early medieval rural restructuring, but they must be read with ground-level caution. **Why this earns marks:** It converts document form into social mechanism and keeps a source limit visible.

Original Mains Practice 03 - 15 marks - 250 words

Critically examine the Indian feudalism thesis with reference to the transition from ancient to early medieval India.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Indian feudalism thesis remains indispensable as a heuristic, but it is too blunt if used as a total description of c. AD 300-1200. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] R. S. Sharma highlighted royal land grants, transfer of fiscal and judicial rights, labour dependence, samanta obligations, payment of officials through land assignments, trade decline and urban contraction. Upinder's summary of this thesis shows exactly why it was

powerful: it forced historians to connect polity, agrarian relations and exchange. Sharma's own treatment of peasants being tied to granted land and his contrast between Pataliputra and Kannauj add real structural force. D. D. Kosambi's materialist line also linked landed magnates and cultural change. [ANALYSIS] Yet later historians challenged the model's total reach. Harbans Mukhia-type critiques object that the European manor-serf bundle cannot be simply imported into India. Chattopadhyaya and Kulke show that the same centuries also saw state formation, not merely disintegration. Upinder similarly argues that land grants could be integrative and legitimising rather than simple proof of royal collapse. [LIMIT] The evidence is regionally uneven, and urban or monetary change does not follow one line everywhere. [VERDICT] Indian feudalism is therefore most useful as a limited analytical lens for labour dependence, intermediation and uneven urban change; it becomes misleading when treated as a universal master key. **Why this earns marks:** It stages thesis, evidence, critique and a bounded verdict in the directive's own critical register.

Original Mains Practice 04 - 15 marks - 250 words

Compare Brahmanisation with localisation as ways of explaining early medieval social change.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Brahmanisation and localisation are not rival slogans so much as two levels of the same early medieval process. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Sharma shows how priests gave chiefs respectable genealogies, how agraharas and brahmadeyas spread into frontier zones, and how Sanskrit charters and varna claims reordered new regions such as Odisha. Topic 23 adds that Pallava and Chalukya grants, shrine patronage and bhakti worked through temple-centred localities. Upinder then sharpens the picture: land grants to Brahmanas were integrative strategies, while local cults and elites actively reshaped the received idiom. [ANALYSIS] "Brahmanisation" is strongest when used for the spread of Brahmana-linked ritual, law, calendars, genealogy and status. "Localisation" is strongest when used for the adaptation of these wider idioms within specific sacred places, local languages, donor communities and cult traditions. The two meet in temple towns, regional languages and reworked deities such as Jagannatha. [LIMIT] Both terms can become too smooth if conflict, hierarchy and resistance are ignored. [VERDICT] The most defensible answer therefore treats Brahmanisation as the wider ideological-political movement and localisation as its regionally negotiated, uneven and often reciprocal embedding. **Why this earns marks:** It compares without flattening, uses named evidence from east and south and ends with a conceptual distinction.

Original Mains Practice 05 - 20 marks - 250 words

Evaluate the proposition that early medieval India witnessed urban transformation rather than blanket urban decline.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The proposition is broadly persuasive, provided one does not deny genuine decline in some older centres. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Sharma's urban-decay thesis, as summarised by Upinder, linked long-distance trade decline to artisan migration, weaker trader capacity and a blurred town-village distinction. This remains important because some sites did contract. However, Upinder also marshals the counter-case: texts, inscriptions and archaeology reveal continued or renewed urban life in centres such as Thaneshwar, Varanasi and Kanyakubja, and Chattopadhyaya's evidence from Pehoa, Ahar, Siyadoni and Gwalior points to 9th-10th century urbanity. Mandapikas, pattanas and nagarams show a reconfigured market hierarchy, not a void. Temple towns, pilgrimage centres and fortified capitals further broaden the urban vocabulary. Deyell's monetary work likewise warns that coin change is not equivalent to economic collapse. [ANALYSIS] Thus the strongest reading is not "decline versus no decline" but "functional reorganisation." The relative weight of political, sacred, market and port functions changed from region to region. [LIMIT] Early medieval archaeology remains uneven, so silence cannot be overread. [VERDICT] Blanket urban decline is too crude; the better verdict is partial contraction combined with substantial transformation and regional regeneration. **Why this earns marks:** It grants real force to the decline thesis, names counter-evidence and reaches a graded conclusion rather than a slogan.

Original Mains Practice 06 - 20 marks - 250 words

Why is the ancient-to-early medieval transition historically significant for understanding later Indian regional cultures and institutions?

Model answer: [CLAIM] The transition is historically significant because it produced many of the durable regional institutions, identities and cultural idioms that later Indian history inherited and reworked. [NAMED EVIDENCE -> MECHANISM] Politically, the weakening of large imperial concentration and the growth of samanta-linked hierarchies

generated regionally anchored state systems in the east, Deccan and south. Agrarianly, land grants, irrigation and frontier settlement created thicker rural societies and stronger intermediaries. Religiously, Puranic sects, bhakti, tantra and temple patronage tied sacred geographies to locality and kingship. Institutionally, temples and monasteries became landholders, employers, archives and redistributors; Nalanda and later eastern mahaviharas show how knowledge, surplus and connectivity could be concentrated. Linguistically, Sanskrit prestige endured while vernacularisation made regional political-literary cultures increasingly visible. [ANALYSIS] These changes did not destroy ancient inheritances; they transformed them. That is why later Chola power, medieval temple architecture, Bhakti movements and regional literary traditions make more sense when read as developments of early medieval structures. [LIMIT] The process was uneven and often hierarchical; exclusion, patriarchy and contest remained integral to it. [VERDICT] The ancient-to-early medieval transition matters because it turned older repertoires into regionally durable social and institutional worlds rather than leaving a simple story of decline. **Why this earns marks:** It integrates polity, economy, religion, language and legacy into one causal significance answer and closes with a balanced verdict.

Final examiner checklist for Topic 26 answers

Use this before closing any long answer or before self-marking a workbook response.

If the answer discusses...	Do not miss
periodisation	no single transition date; use heuristic phases carefully
polity	regional state formation plus samantas or layered sovereignty
land grants	one concrete right, one social effect, one source caution
feudalism debate	Sharma + one critique + bounded verdict
economy / towns	decline in some centres + transformation in others
social history	varna / jati distinction and one exclusion or mobility example
religion	Puranic growth + bhakti / tantra + Buddhist / Jaina persistence
institutions	temple or monastery as labour / archive / legitimacy node
language	Sanskrit prestige plus vernacularisation, not simple replacement
conclusion	regional cultures and durable institutions, not "mere decline"

- If you cite a charter, say what right it transferred.
- If you say "regional variation", name at least one region.
- If you say "legacy", classify it as survival, transformation or reinvention.
- If you mention Nalanda, add the agrarian support base and a number-caution line.